

Game Design Document (Draft)

Project Title: *TBD*

1. High Concept

Genre

- Story-Driven Turn-Based RPG
- Adventure
- Puzzle Exploration

Platform

- PC

Engine

- Unity

Estimated Playtime

2–4 Hours

Team Scope

Designed specifically for a **2-month game jam** with a small team.

Elevator Pitch

A story-driven turn-based RPG where players explore the ruins of an ancient underwater civilization. Rather than simply attacking enemies until they run out of health, players strategically target different body parts to disable abilities, alter enemy behavior, and solve each battle like a tactical puzzle.

Exploration is inspired by classic Zelda games, with interconnected environments, environmental puzzles, hidden secrets, and relics that unlock both new exploration abilities and new combat options.

The experience focuses on meaningful choices, discovery, and storytelling over grinding or large character statistics.

Design Pillars

Tactical Combat

Every attack should feel meaningful.

Players choose **what to disable**, not simply **what to damage**.

Exploration Rewards Curiosity

Players should constantly wonder:

"What's behind that door?"

"Can I come back here later?"

Story First

Combat and exploration both exist to support the narrative.

Every dungeon, relic, puzzle, and boss should reveal another piece of the world's history.

Small Scope, High Polish

Rather than dozens of mechanics, every mechanic should appear throughout the game in increasingly interesting ways.

Core Gameplay Loop

Explore



Solve Environmental Puzzle



Unlock New Area



Encounter Enemy



Analyze Enemy



Target Body Parts



Disable Enemy Abilities



Continue Story



Find New Relic



Previously Locked Areas Become Accessible



Repeat

Story

The game takes place beneath the ocean, within the remains of a once-thriving mermaid civilization.

Long ago, powerful songs maintained balance throughout the sea. Those songs have faded, and corruption now spreads through creatures, ruins, and forgotten temples.

The player embarks on a journey to uncover what happened to the civilization and determine whether its legacy should be restored or left to disappear.

The story unfolds primarily through exploration, conversations, environmental storytelling, and optional discoveries rather than lengthy exposition.

Core Combat System

Combat is entirely turn-based.

Instead of simply selecting an enemy and attacking, players choose **which body part to target**.

Each enemy consists of:

- Head
- Left Arm
- Right Arm
- Torso
- Tail (or equivalent movement limb)

Each body part has its own durability.

Breaking a body part permanently changes that enemy for the remainder of combat.

Players must decide whether removing dangerous abilities is more valuable than dealing direct damage.

Body Part Effects

Head

Primary Function

Awareness and concentration.

Breaking it may:

- Reduce accuracy
- Cause confusion
- Disable magical concentration
- Interrupt powerful abilities

Left Arm

Primary Function

Defense.

Breaking it may:

- Disable shields

- Prevent guarding
 - Remove counterattacks
 - Lower defensive stats
-

Right Arm

Primary Function

Attack.

Breaking it may:

- Disable weapon skills
 - Remove heavy attacks
 - Reduce damage output
 - Prevent spell casting requiring a focus
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Torso

Primary Function

Vital center.

Breaking it does not remove abilities but:

- Deals the highest HP damage
 - Increases stagger chance
 - Makes finishing enemies easier
-

Tail / Movement Limb

Primary Function

Mobility.

Breaking it may:

- Lower movement speed
- Reduce dodge chance
- Delay actions
- Prevent repositioning abilities

Different enemy types may substitute wings, tentacles, fins, or legs while following the same design philosophy.

Enemy Design Philosophy

Each enemy should revolve around one defining mechanic.

Rather than simply increasing health, enemies challenge the player by encouraging different targeting priorities.

Examples include:

- Defensive enemies protected by shields
- Fast enemies relying on mobility
- Spellcasters channeling powerful magic
- Support enemies buffing allies
- Aggressive attackers with devastating weapon skills

The player learns to identify and dismantle these strengths through targeted attacks.

Player Abilities

Rather than unlocking dozens of attacks, players gain a small collection of versatile abilities that remain useful throughout the game.

Possible ability categories include:

Basic Attack

Reliable damage.

Targets any body part.

Defensive Ability

Protect allies or reduce incoming damage.

Healing Song

Restore health.

Cannot repair broken body parts during battle.

Analysis Song

Reveal enemy weaknesses or highlight important body parts.

Support Ability

Manipulate turn order, increase accuracy, or strengthen allies.

Ultimate Ability

Powerful attack earned through gameplay rather than passive cooldowns.

Resonance System

Successfully breaking body parts generates **Resonance**.

Resonance represents the disruption of corrupted sea magic.

Players spend Resonance on powerful tactical abilities.

Possible uses include:

- Extra turn
- Strong healing
- Party-wide buffs
- Powerful attacks
- Emergency defensive abilities

This rewards tactical play instead of simply maximizing damage.

Exploration

Exploration is inspired by classic Zelda games.

Areas contain:

- Locked doors
- Hidden caves
- Ancient mechanisms
- Optional treasures
- Puzzle rooms
- NPCs
- Secret shortcuts

The world gradually opens as players obtain new relics.

Exploration rewards observation rather than exhaustive searching.

Relics

Progression is tied to relics rather than traditional leveling.

Each relic serves two purposes:

1. Unlock new exploration mechanics.
2. Expand combat possibilities.

Examples of relic functions include:

- Cutting barriers
- Manipulating currents

- Revealing hidden pathways
- Activating ancient mechanisms
- Crossing hazardous environments
- Revealing invisible objects
- Interacting with forgotten technology

Relics encourage revisiting previous areas to uncover optional rewards and new story content.

Environmental Puzzles

Puzzles should be readable, intuitive, and based on mechanics introduced earlier in the game.

Puzzle types may include:

- Redirecting water currents
- Moving coral blocks
- Musical sequence puzzles
- Pressure switches
- Light reflection
- Ancient machinery
- Timed mechanisms
- Hidden pathways
- Environmental interactions using newly acquired relics

Later areas combine multiple mechanics to create more complex challenges.

World Structure

The game follows a semi-linear structure.

Players progress through distinct regions while occasionally revisiting earlier locations after obtaining new relics.

Each major area generally contains:

- Story progression
- Exploration
- Environmental puzzles
- New enemy types
- Optional secrets
- Relic acquisition
- Boss encounter

The exact number and themes of regions will be determined during production.

NPCs

NPCs serve multiple purposes:

- Advance the narrative
- Provide world-building
- Offer optional side stories
- Explain puzzle mechanics naturally
- Reward exploration

Rather than relying on quest markers, NPC dialogue should encourage curiosity and exploration.

Collectibles

Optional discoveries provide additional lore and player progression.

Potential collectibles include:

- Memory fragments
- Ancient songs
- Bestiary entries
- Historical journals
- Cosmetic equipment
- Upgrade materials

Collectibles should deepen the player's understanding of the world rather than simply increase statistics.

Progression

Character progression focuses on expanding player options instead of increasing numerical power.

Players improve by obtaining:

- New relics
- New songs
- New combat techniques
- Story knowledge
- Better tactical understanding

The player should feel more capable because they have learned new mechanics rather than because their attack stat increased.

Boss Design

Bosses should function as puzzles.

Rather than possessing enormous health pools, bosses encourage players to identify and dismantle specific abilities.

Examples of boss mechanics include:

- Multiple targetable weak points
- Phase changes triggered by disabled body parts
- Environmental interactions
- Puzzle mechanics integrated into combat
- Relic-specific mechanics
- Multiple viable strategies

Every boss should introduce at least one new idea rather than simply increasing difficulty.

Audio Direction

The soundtrack emphasizes mystery, melancholy, and wonder.

Musical themes evolve as the player uncovers the truth about the underwater civilization.

Sound design should reinforce exploration through:

- Flowing water
- Echoing ruins
- Ancient mechanisms
- Coral growth
- Creature vocalizations
- Magical songs

Music also plays an active role in puzzle solving and storytelling.

Visual Direction

The world should contrast beauty with decay.

Visual themes include:

- Ancient underwater architecture
- Bioluminescent plants
- Coral-covered ruins
- Deep ocean darkness
- Soft lighting
- Flowing aquatic movement
- Magical effects inspired by ocean life

Enemies should visually communicate which body parts are most important to their abilities.

Technical Scope

The project intentionally limits its scope to remain achievable.

Primary systems include:

- Turn-based combat
- Targetable body parts
- Enemy behavior changes
- Exploration
- Environmental puzzles
- Relic progression
- Dialogue system
- Save/load
- Inventory
- Basic equipment
- Boss encounters

Features intentionally avoided for this project include:

- Procedural generation
 - Large open world
 - Extensive crafting systems
 - Complex party customization
 - Online multiplayer
 - Branching combat classes
 - Hundreds of unique items
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Development Goals

The game should stand out through the combination of three tightly integrated systems:

1. **Body-Part Tactical Combat** – Every attack is a meaningful choice that changes the battle by disabling enemy capabilities.
2. **Relic-Based Exploration** – New tools continuously reshape how players interact with the world, unlocking hidden paths and new puzzle solutions.
3. **Story-Driven Adventure** – Exploration, combat, and progression all support the mystery of a fallen underwater civilization, creating an experience where discovery is just as rewarding as victory.

Rather than competing with larger RPGs on size or complexity, the project aims to deliver a polished, memorable experience built around one central question: **How do you defeat an enemy when removing its abilities is more important than reducing its health?**

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